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STUDY GUIDE for DAVID HUME: *AN INQUIRY CONCERNING HUMAN UNDERSTANDING*

by

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{First, read all the front matter in your Hackett edition of Hume's *An Inquiry concerning Human Understanding* as well as Hume's *A Letter from a Gentleman to his Friend in Edinburgh*, which appears at the end of the book. Inspect the table of contents to get a sense of what's in Hume's *Inquiry*. Read the editor's introduction (Eric Steinberg is the editor) for background information about Hume's life and work. The letter to his friend in Edinburgh will give you some idea of the religious opposition to Hume (they played hardball in those days) and how Hume answers it, not always ingenuously as you will soon learn. Look over the Hume bibliography to get a feel for the amount and range of his published work. Read the "Advertisement" placed opposite the first page of the *Inquiry* so that you can see what Hume took to be the relationship of the present *Inquiry* to his youthful *magnum opus* entitled *A Treatise of Human Nature*.}

Section I: Of the Different Species of Philosophy

1. Hume means by moral philosophy something very different from what this term means today. What does Hume mean by it? How is the term used nowadays?

2 Hume distinguishes two types of philosophy which Professor Massey calls soft philosophy (Hume's easy and humane philosophy) and hard philosophy (Hume's accurate and abstruse philosophy). How do these two types of philosophy differ from one another? What are their respective advantages and disadvantages? (It may help you to sort matters out if you keep in mind that Hume sees himself as practicing accurate and abstruse philosophy, i.e., hard philosophy.) Which three philosophers does Hume himself name as practitioners of accurate and abstruse philosophy? Which three does he name as practitioners of easy and humane philosophy? What does Hume mean in this Section by metaphysics?

3. Hume is convinced that religion, which he calls superstition, has infiltrated hard philosophy so as to produce pseudo-metaphysical nonsense to cover up and protect its weakness. What does he think is the sole and universal remedy for debunking the pretensions of pseudo-metaphysics?

4. What is the new method (pioneered by John Locke) in philosophy that Hume proposes to follow? Is it appropriate to call it the epistemic turn? (Did Descartes follow it?) What negative benefit does Hume hope to achieve by it? What positive benefits? Is Hume skeptical about our ability to understand basic facts about the operations of our minds?

5. What does Hume mean by mental geography? Why does he attach considerable importance to taxonomy of the mind when he clearly recognizes that taxonomy has very little value in the sciences that deal with physical things? Does he have any hope that moral science will advance beyond this taxonomic stage? Is it legitimate to search for a few simple laws to systematize and explain a large mass of taxonomically

organized data about the mind? Does Hume despair of the advent of a Newton of the mind? What two achievements does Hume hope for from this Inquiry?

Section II: Of the Origin of Ideas

1. What is a perception of the mind? What examples does Hume give? Hume divides the perceptions of the mind into two mutually exclusive and jointly exhaustive classes, namely, thoughts or ideas and impressions. What is the basis for this division? What examples does Hume give of each class? How adequate is this division, i.e., is it really mutually exclusive (i.e., no perception belongs to both classes) and jointly exhaustive (i.e., every perception belongs to one or the other of the classes) of the perceptions of the mind? Is Hume's use of the term impression standard for his day?

2. What can we think of, i.e., what ideas are we able to have? Why does our thought appear to be unlimited, i.e., why does there seem to be no limits to what we can form ideas of? Can we conceive or think things that imply contradictions? What does Hume take the materials of thought to be? Where do they come from? What does Hume take the bounds or limits of thought to be?

3. For Hume, simple ideas are faint copies of impressions, whereas complex ideas are ensembles or assemblages of simple ideas. Is every idea either simple or complex? By what mental operations does the mind construct or fabricate complex ideas out of simple ones? What examples does Hume give of simple ideas? What examples does he give of complex ideas formed out of simple ideas? Where do we get the idea of God as an infinitely intelligent, wise and good Being?

4. Hume advances two important universal theses about ideas. First, every simple idea is a copy of an impression of inner or outer sense. Second, every complex idea is a bundle or assemblage of simple ideas, i.e., complex ideas are structured ensembles of simple ideas. Hume offers two arguments for these theses. The first argument turns on the observation that, whenever we try to do so, we can always reduce a complex idea to simple ideas that are copies of impressions. The second argument features people who lack one of the senses (e.g., taste or sight) or who have never been exposed to an object that excites a certain impression, e.g., a congenitally blind person who has never experienced colors or an Eskimo who has never tasted pineapple. Set out these two arguments in detail. Which thesis does each support? How probative are they? How, according to Hume, can an opponent refute the first thesis?

5. What is the missing-shade-of-blue thought experiment all about? Is it a counterexample to the first thesis mentioned in 4. above? If so, why doesn't Hume discard the thesis, especially since he boasted that it takes only a single counterexample to refute the thesis? How does Hume resolve the anomaly of the missing shade of blue? Does he qualify or restrict his general rule that all simple ideas are copies of impressions?

6. How does Hume propose to use his theory of ideas to cut through obfuscation and pseudo-profound philosophical talk (the method is sometimes called Hume's microscope)? To discredit a philosophical idea (in Hume's sense of idea), is it enough to show that it is not a faint copy of any impression? Why not? How does Hume relate the doctrine of innate ideas to his theses that simple ideas are copies of impressions, whereas complex ideas are assemblages of simple ideas?

Section III: Of the Association of Ideas

1. Why does Hume think that the flow or stream of our ideas is not random, but is governed by principles or laws of connection or association? Formulate his principles of the association or connection of ideas,

namely: Resemblance, Contiguity in time or place, and Cause or Effect. Give illustrations of each principle.

2. Hume thinks everyone will concede that his three principles really do connect or associate ideas one with another. What he thinks is controversial is his implicit claim that these three principles suffice, i.e., that any other principle of association of ideas is reducible to these three. How does he think one might establish the completeness of his three principles of association of ideas? How does he reduce the principle of Contrast or Contrariety to his three principles? Is it mere coincidence that Newton formulated three laws of motion?

{Like Section II, section IV is one of the most important in the entire book. In a sense, sections II and IV constitute the core of Hume's *Inquiry*.}

Section IV: Sceptical Doubts concerning the Operations of the Understanding

Part I

1. Hume claims that all objects of human reason or inquiry (all propositions) fall into one of two classes: relations of ideas and matters of fact (this division is called Hume's Fork). What examples does he give of relations of ideas? In what sciences or disciplines does one usually find them? Only in mathematics? Are they discovered or known a priori or a posteriori? Explain the difference between a priori and a posteriori.

2. What examples does Hume give of matters of fact? Where does one find or meet such propositions? Are matters of fact known a priori or a posteriori? Are their contraries possible or conceivable? Are their contradictories possible or conceivable?

3. What, according to Hume, enables us to get beyond memory and sense perception, i.e., what enables us to know things that are present neither to sense nor to memory? What examples does he give?

4. Hume claims that we never come to know cause-effect relationships a priori but always a posteriori, i.e., from experience. What is the thought experiment about Adam supposed to show? Do people tend to think they have a priori insight into causal relationships in the case of novel objects or in the case of things dramatically different from those of everyday experience? What about cases where the causal mechanism is supposed to be highly complicated or to depend on hidden structure? What about cases where the events are familiar, simple, and without apparent hidden structure, e.g., collisions and motions of ordinary billiard balls?

5. Spell out Hume's argument for the a posteriori character of causal knowledge, which takes as its premiss the observation that effect and cause are totally different, i.e., that they are distinct events.

6. Why does Hume limit the role of human reason in causal matters to reduction and systematization, i.e., to reducing the number and kinds of causes to a few general ones and to explaining the former in terms of the latter? Why isn't applied mathematics an exception to this claim?

Part II

7. What is the nature of all reasonings concerning matters of fact? What is the foundation of all our reasonings and conclusions concerning cause-and-effect? How do these two questions differ from the new one which Hume now raises, namely, what is the foundation of all conclusions from experience? Formulate Hume's negative answer to this new question, i.e., on what does he say these conclusions do not depend?

8. What is the utmost that past experience can tell us about which objects follow upon which other objects? What accounts for our extrapolation to the future and to unobserved objects?

9. What logical connection or logical relation holds between the following two propositions?
   a. I have found that such an object has always been attended with such an effect.
   b. I foresee that other objects similar in appearance will be attended with similar effects.

Is this connection or relation intuitive (analytic)? Is it demonstrative, i.e., can one deduce the second proposition from the first? Give Hume's arguments for these conclusions.

10. According to Hume, all experimental conclusions (conclusions based on experience) are based on or presuppose the principle that the future will be like the past (the so-called Principle of the Uniformity of Nature). What leads us to expect similar effects from similar causes? Does a single instance of cause and effect suffice to mold our expectation? Why not? What does this fact show?

11. If the inference in 9. above from proposition a. to proposition b. is neither intuitive nor demonstrative, what kind of inference might it be? If, in addition, this inference is not experimental (based on experience), what possibilities remain for it?

12. How does Hume defuse the objection that all that he has shown is that he can't find a reason or argument that permits him in 9. above to infer proposition b. from proposition a.? What is the relevance to this of his observation that stupid people and even infants acquire considerable knowledge of cause-and-effect?

Section V: Sceptical Solution of these Doubts

Part I

1. Hume thinks that, like religion, many species of philosophy can corrupt morals, reduce enjoyment of life, and make us lazy and presumptuous. How is scepticism (academical philosophy) supposed to avoid these pitfalls? Won't scepticism paralyze us into inaction? E.g., if a person realizes that no reason can be given for inductive inferences (causal inferences), won't he or she hesitate to make such inferences or at least hesitate to act on them?

2. Do single cases or single instances of the conjunction of two objects give rise to the idea of cause-and-effect? If not, why does a multiplicity of cases give rise to this idea? What do the foregoing facts show about the role of reason in generating this idea? Could reasoning by itself ever get beyond what is immediately present to the senses or to memory?

3. Reason does not prompt us to draw conclusions from experience, i.e., to make inductive or causal inferences, so what principle does prompt such inferences? What is *custom*? Is it a type of instinct? How does the invocation of custom (habit) remove the difficulty about multiple-case versus single-case causal inferences? Without custom, what would the range of human knowledge be?

4. How do we move beyond the hypothetical in our beliefs? If we had no senses and no memory, would all our reasonings be hypothetical? Can we, by reasoning about it, resist custom (habit) when it leads us to infer one thing from another thing that is present to our senses or memory when we have found the two things constantly conjoined in our experience? Is it custom or will, then, that determines what we believe about matters of fact? Was Descartes wrong to think that we have it always within our power to suspend judgment on any proposition that we do not clearly and distinctly perceive to be true?

5. Belief is only one of many propositional attitudes. Besides believing a proposition, one might merely entertain it or doubt it or imagine it to be true or wish it true or the like. How does belief differ from other propositional attitudes? How, in particular, does belief differ from imagining (i.e., pretending) that a proposition is true (i.e., fiction) or from merely entertaining (i.e., considering) a proposition?

6. Hume makes *belief* in a proposition a matter of a certain feeling or sentiment which accompanies the proposition in our mind. Does Hume offer a definition of this feeling? Why not? Describe the feeling or sentiment of belief? If we were incapable of feeling, would we have beliefs? What would Hume say about the choice of words of someone who expressed his or her belief about the forthcoming presidential election thus: *I feel* that the Democratic candidate is going to thrash the Republican candidate?

7. Hume posits three principles that govern *the association of ideas*, namely: *resemblance*, *contiguity,* and *causation*. Causation, he has already argued, produces a lively and steady conception of the effect when the cause is present to sense or memory. Do the other two principles of association also do this, i.e., in addition to evoking the idea of the resembled thing or of the contiguous thing, do they also engender a lively and steady conception of this thing? What "experiments" does Hume appeal to in order to substantiate his claim? Do these two principles of association lead to a lively and steady conception of an object when what triggered the idea of the object was another idea without any impression annexed to it? Why can't resemblance and contiguity by themselves ever lead to belief about real existence beyond what is present to sense or memory? What do beliefs prompted by resemblance or contiguity presuppose which not also presupposed by beliefs that are prompted by causation?

8. Hume speaks of a sort of *pre-established harmony* between the course of nature and the course of our ideas. To what harmony or correlation is he referring? Is the principle that effects this correlation reason or custom (habit)? Why is it advantageous to the human organism that it be custom rather than reason that establishes this correspondence? Try to cast your answer to this last question in the form of a Darwinian explanation of the role of inductive instinct (custom or habit) in belief formation.

Section VI: Of Probability